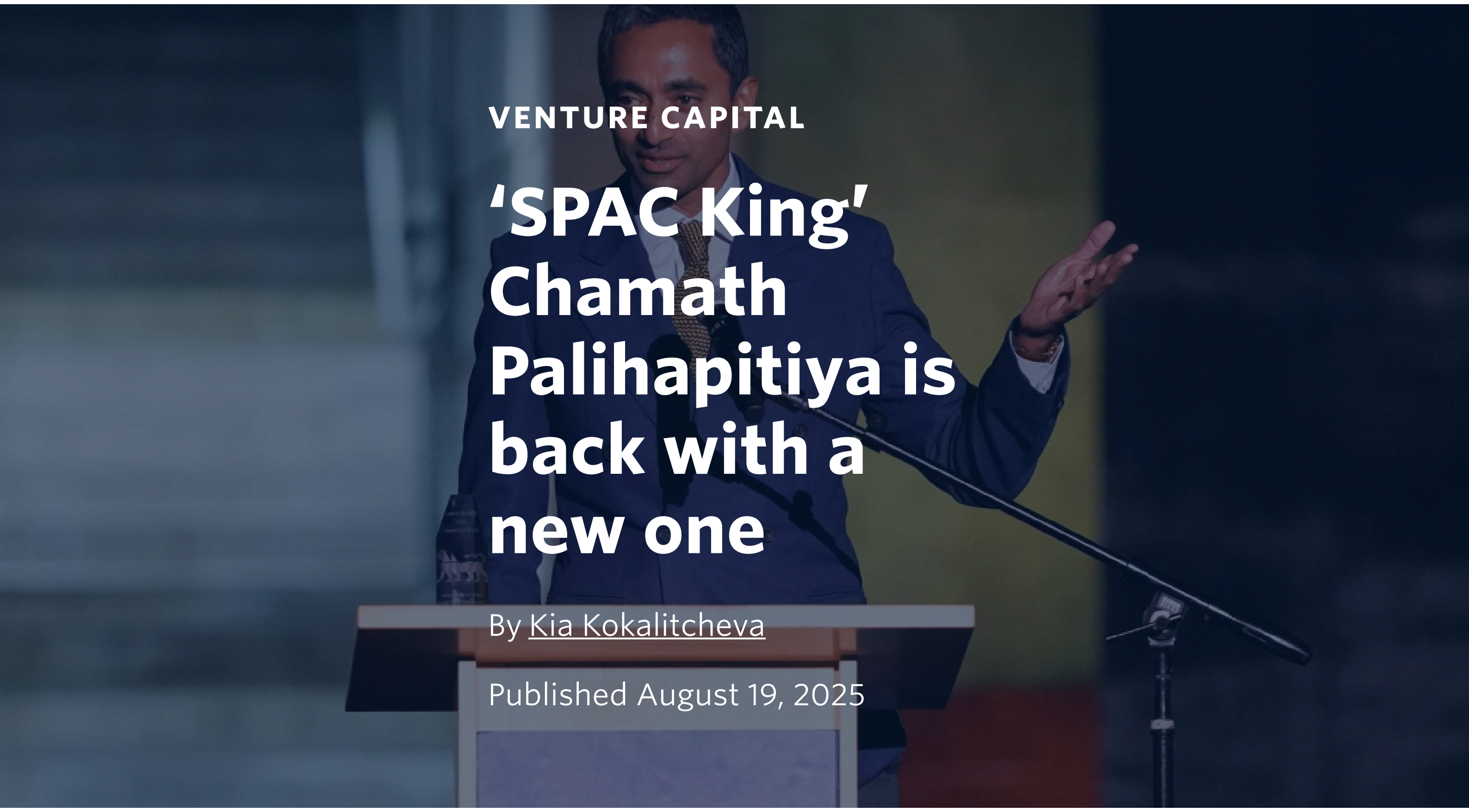

VENTURE CAPITAL

'SPAC King' Chamath Palihapitiya is back with a new one

By Kia Kokalitcheva

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Silicon Valley investor Chamath Palihapitiya has filed documents with the SEC for a new special purpose acquisition company, this time mainly focused on energy, AI, decentralized finance and defense.

Palihapitiya, dubbed by many in the industry as the "SPAC King," was early in promoting SPACs as an IPO alternative. He was eventually criticized for helping usher in a flood of capital and deals that fared poorly.

American Exceptionalism Acquisition Corp. A is seeking to raise $250 million via an IPO by selling 25 million shares at $10 each.

"I believe the biggest gains in the future will come from companies that are involved in fixing the fundamental risks that come from our interconnected global order while reinforcing American exceptionalism," wrote Palihapitiya in the founder letter included in the document, while also acknowledging that SPACs are not suited to every company.

This new vehicle's theme is in line with Silicon Valley's reignited interest in sectors such as defense and domestic infrastructure. Venture capital firms have been increasingly investing in these categories amid the current Trump administration's notable openness to working with Silicon Valley. Palihapitiya came out in support of then-presidential candidate Donald Trump last year, alongside a growing cadre of fellow startup investors.

The SPAC's founder shares—the equity the vehicle's sponsor earns—will notably only vest if the post-merger business achieves at least a 50% stock price increase, though it will be a hefty stake: 30% instead of the common 20%. Sponsors were heavily criticized during the pandemic-era SPAC mania for essentially getting sizable stakes in the combined business at nominal prices, then generating high returns if the business performed well in the public market.

Palihapitiya had previously sponsored 10 SPACs since his first in 2017, according to SPAC Research. Four were eventually liquidated, while the rest merged with companies including Virgin Galactic, Opendoor, SoFi, and Clover Health.

Chamath Palihapitiya at the 2023 Asia Society Southern California Annual Gala./Featured image by Variety/Variety via Getty Images

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About Kia Kokalitcheva

Kia Kokalitcheva leads PitchBook's US venture capital news team and is based in San Francisco. With over a decade of experience covering Silicon Valley, startups, VCs, and the broader dealmaking world, she brings deep expertise and curiosity to the newsroom. Kia previously worked at Axios, Fortune, and VentureBeat. She holds a bachelor's degree in Political Economy from UC Berkeley, where she was a columnist for its award-winning student newspaper, The Daily Californian.

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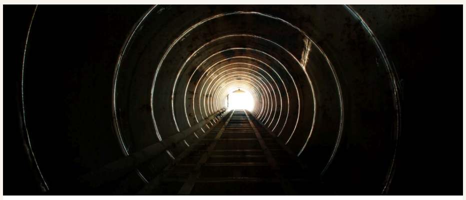

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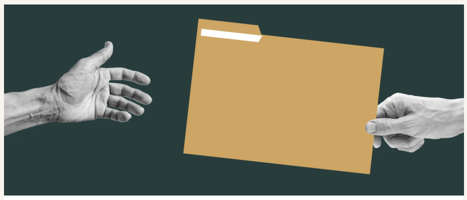

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